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Skilled by the Spirit: Moses, the Tabernacle, and the Craft That Is Given, Not Autonomous

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Abstract

Paper 4 argued that the call of Abraham reveals the steward as one called to build against entropy by faith, for a promise he will not live to see. The present paper takes up the second stage of the covenant line — the Moses narrative of deliverance, Law, and tabernacle — and asks what it discloses about the *tool* and the *skill* by which the steward builds. Its claim turns on a figure the technology debate has almost entirely overlooked: Bezalel, the craftsman whom God "filled with the Spirit of God, with ability and intelligence, with knowledge and all craftsmanship" (Ex 31:3,

ESV) to build the tabernacle. The paper argues that the Bezalel narrative is Scripture's clearest statement of a theology of skill and technology: that craft is a divine endowment, given by the Spirit for a purpose, exercised under a governing pattern, and including the ability to teach it to others — and that technique, on this reading, is never autonomous but always instrumental, given, and governed. The contemporary frame the paper answers is the thesis of autonomous technology in its most serious form — Jacques Ellul's argument that "technique" has become a self-augmenting, self-justifying force that subordinates its makers and obeys its own law, and the techno-determinist tradition that follows him. Against that thesis the paper argues that the danger Ellul truly names — technique escaping its governance and demanding autonomy — is real, and is the technological form of the idolatry the series has tracked from Babel; but that its remedy is not the abandonment of technique but its return to the Bezalel pattern: skill received as gift, exercised under the steward's governance, ordered to worship and the neighbor's good. The paper sets this within the Mosaic structure of grace-before-law — the deliverance precedes the commandments, so that the Law governs a people already redeemed — and carries the series guardrail: Moses' sin at the rock costs him Canaan but undoes neither the deliverance nor the Law that God worked through him. The seven-problem spine is carried, featuring governance (#6) in its technological register: why the human must govern the tool rather than defer to it is answered by the doctrine of given skill under a given pattern.

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§1. The Question and the World's Claim

The Moses narrative is the covenant's second great movement, and it is organized around three divine works: a *deliverance* (the exodus from Egypt), a *law* (the covenant at Sinai), and a *dwelling* (the tabernacle, built so that God might dwell among his redeemed people). Each bears on the steward's vocation, but it is the third — and a single craftsman within it — that this paper takes as its center, because the tabernacle narrative contains what the rest of Scripture nowhere else states so directly: an account of *skill itself* as a gift of God, and of *craft* as a Spirit-endowed vocation.

The question this raises for the present age is the question of *technique*: what is a tool, what is skill, and whether the technical faculty — the human capacity to make and to master instruments — is something the steward governs or something that, having grown beyond him, now governs the steward. The question has been pressed in the twentieth and twenty-first centuries with a seriousness that the prior, more optimistic centuries of technological progress had not demanded, and its most rigorous statement is the thesis of *autonomous technology*, which deserves to be stated at full strength.

Jacques Ellul's *The Technological Society* is the foundational text. Ellul's argument is not the naïve one that machines will rebel; it is the far more unsettling claim that *technique* — by which he means the totality of methods rationally arrived at and having absolute efficiency in every field of human activity — has become an autonomous, self-augmenting system that obeys its own internal law of development and subordinates every human end to its own imperative of efficiency.[1] On Ellul's account, technique is no longer a collection of tools the human picks up and sets down at will; it has become a milieu, an environment, a quasi-autonomous force that selects for its own growth, that converts every problem into a technical problem solvable only by more technique, and that reshapes the human who imagines himself to be using it. The human does not govern technique; technique governs the human, and the illusion that we remain in control is itself one of technique's products.

The thesis has a substantial lineage. Langdon Winner's *Autonomous Technology* developed the political and philosophical case that large technical systems acquire a momentum that escapes deliberate human direction, and that the question "do artifacts have politics?" must be answered yes — that technologies embody and enforce forms of life that their users did not choose and cannot easily revise.[2] Thomas Hughes's concept of *technological momentum* gave the historical-empirical version: that mature technological systems develop a mass and a direction that resist redirection, so

[1] Jacques Ellul, *The Technological Society*, trans. John Wilkinson (New York: Knopf, 1964; French original *La Technique*, 1954). Ellul's definition of *technique* as "the totality of methods rationally arrived at and having absolute efficiency in every field of human activity," and the thesis of its autonomy and self-augmentation, are developed across the work.

[2] Langdon Winner, *Autonomous Technology: Technics-out-of-Control as a Theme in Political Thought* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1977); and Winner, "Do Artifacts Have Politics?" *Daedalus* 109, no. 1 (1980): 121–136.

that the human relation to them shifts, over a system's life, from shaping it to being shaped by it.[3] And the techno-determinist temperament more broadly — from the optimistic ("technology wants" certain outcomes and we should align with them) to the pessimistic (technique will hollow out the human) — shares the structural claim Ellul stated first: that the technical faculty, having grown beyond a certain threshold, is no longer the steward's instrument but his governor.

The structure of the claim is the claim this paper must answer: that technique is autonomous; that its development obeys its own law and not the steward's purposes; and that the human, faced with a sufficiently mature technical system — of which artificial intelligence is the current frontier — must either serve it or be left behind by it, because the one thing he can no longer do is *govern* it. This is the governance problem (Paper 1's Problem #6) in its sharpest technological form: not "should the human govern the capable system?" but "*can* he, or has technique already escaped the possibility of governance?"

This is the position the paper must answer. It will not be answered by pretending technique has no tendency toward autonomy, for the tendency is real and the series has named it.

§2. The Secular Theory, Stated Fairly

It is owed to Ellul above all to say that he is not a Luddite and not a pessimist of the cheap kind, and that the thing he names is real. Ellul's analysis is, in its diagnostic power, one of the most penetrating accounts of modern technology ever written, and a theology of technology that does not reckon with it will be the poorer and the more naïve.

What Ellul names truly is the *tendency of technique toward autonomy*. He observes, with abundant evidence, that technical systems do develop an internal logic of self-augmentation: that each technical solution generates new problems solvable only by further technique; that the imperative of efficiency, once installed as the governing value, colonizes domains — politics, art, human relationship — that were not originally technical and reshapes them in its image; and that the human

[3] Thomas P. Hughes, "Technological Momentum," in *Does Technology Drive History? The Dilemma of Technological Determinism*, ed. Merritt Roe Smith and Leo Marx (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1994), 101–113.

who lives within a sufficiently developed technical milieu finds his options, his perceptions, and even his desires pre-shaped by the system he imagines himself to command. None of this is fantasy. The series has, in fact, named the same tendency under a different description: it is the Babel impulse of Paper 2 — technology conscripted into self-augmentation and autonomy-from-God — observed now from the inside by a sociologist with no theological commitments and confirmed in its structure. On the bare claim that technique *tends* toward autonomy and that this tendency is dangerous, Ellul and the steward agree, and the agreement is deep.

What Ellul also sees rightly is that the tendency is not neutralized by good intentions. The individual technician who means well is, on Ellul's account, no match for the systemic logic; the system selects for its own growth regardless of the morality of its operators, and the belief that one can use a powerful technique for good while remaining unshaped by it is precisely the illusion the technique fosters. Here too the series has named the same structure: the abdication of Paper 2 is a Fall-shaped move that operates *whether or not* the one making it recognizes it, and the over-reach of capability-as-qualification operates by systemic logic and not only by individual vice. Ellul's refusal to let the technician off the hook with good intentions is continuous with the doctrine's seriousness about structural, not merely individual, sin.

Ellul is not alone, and the tradition he anchors gives his diagnosis its full weight. Carl Mitcham's mapping of the philosophy of technology situates Ellul within a broader twentieth-century reckoning in which technique ceases to be a neutral means and becomes a way of disclosing — and disposing of — the world.[4] Martin Heidegger had named the deepest form of the worry: the essence of modern technology is *Gestell*, "enframing," a mode of revealing that sets upon the world as "standing-reserve," raw material on call for ordering — and, fatefully, sets upon the human as one more resource to be optimized.[5] Albert Borgmann gave the worry its everyday texture in the "device paradigm": technology characteristically converts engaging practices, which gather a world

[4]Carl Mitcham, *Thinking through Technology: The Path between Engineering and Philosophy* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1994). Situates Ellul within the broader philosophy of technology. [^VERIFY: pin pages at audit.]

[5]Martin Heidegger, "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954), in *The Question Concerning Technology and Other Essays*, trans. William Lovitt (New York: Harper & Row, 1977). The essence of modern technology as *Gestell* (enframing); the world disclosed as standing-reserve.

and form a person, into frictionless commodities that demand nothing and form no one — the hearth replaced by the thermostat, the shared meal by the microwaved one.[6] And David Noble traced the religious genealogy of the whole project, showing that the Western pursuit of technology has carried, from the medieval period forward, an explicitly redemptive charge — the recovery of lost perfection, transcendence, even divinity, through making.[7] The convergence of these analyses with the series is granted in full: technique does tend to enframe, to disengage, to promise salvation, and to set upon the human as standing-reserve. This is the Babel impulse of Paper 2 observed from inside the modern technical condition, and the error, if there is one, is not in the diagnosis.

The divergence is over whether the tendency is *destiny*. Ellul, having diagnosed the autonomy of technique with unmatched power, has — by his own framework — almost no resource for *remedy*. Technique is autonomous; the human is shaped by it; the diagnosis is total; and the most Ellul can finally offer is a kind of lucid, sacramental refusal — a witness against technique that does not pretend to govern it. The reason is structural: Ellul's analysis grants technique a quasi-ontological autonomy, and once that grant is made, governance is foreclosed in principle, because one cannot govern what is by definition autonomous. The steward reading makes a different and prior claim: that technique is *not* ontologically autonomous, that skill is a *given* faculty and not a self-existing force, and that the tendency toward autonomy Ellul truly observes is not technique's nature but technique's *idolatry* — the same disordering the series has tracked, in which a good gift, ungoverned, sets up as a god. The divergence, then, is not over whether technique tends toward autonomy. It is over whether that tendency is the truth of technique or the corruption of it.

§3. Common Ground and the Point of Divergence

The cleavage is locatable, and it is a question about the *origin and ownership of skill*. Is the technical faculty a self-existing force that the human happens to host and that, beyond a threshold, hosts the

[6] Albert Borgmann, *Technology and the Character of Contemporary Life: A Philosophical Inquiry* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1984). The "device paradigm": engaging practices displaced by frictionless commodities. [^VERIFY: pin device-paradigm pages at audit.]

[7] David F. Noble, *The Religion of Technology: The Divinity of Man and the Spirit of Invention* (New York: Knopf, 1997). The redemptive/religious genealogy of Western technology.

human in return? Or is it a *gift* — given by God, owned by no autonomous "technique," exercised by a steward who answers for it?

Both Ellul and the steward observe that technique tends to escape governance. They part over what follows from the observation. Ellul infers, from the tendency-toward-autonomy, that technique *is* autonomous — that the tendency reveals technique's nature, and that the human relation to it is therefore, at the limit, one of subjection. The steward reads the same tendency as *corruption* — as the disordering of a good gift, the technological form of the idolatry by which any creaturely good, ungoverned, demands the place of God. The difference is the difference between reading the autonomy-tendency as the *essence* of technique and reading it as the *fall* of technique, and everything follows from which reading is taken.

This is the governance problem (#6) in the register the Mosaic stage gives it. The series grounded the governing office in creation (Paper 1), traced its over-reach and abdication failures (Paper 2), commanded its deployment (Paper 3), and extended it across time (Paper 4). The Moses stage adds the answer to the question those prior stages presupposed but did not establish: *can* the steward govern the tool, or has the tool become ungovernable? And the Bezalel narrative answers: skill is given, not self-existing; it is endowed by the Spirit for a purpose and exercised under a pattern; and a faculty that is given and governed at its origin is not autonomous at its nature, however strongly it may tend, in its corruption, to claim autonomy. The governability of technique rests on the givenness of skill. If skill is a gift, it has an owner and an end, and what has an owner and an end can be governed; if skill is an autonomous force, it has neither, and Ellul is right. The whole question turns on Bezalel.

The divergence, then, is not over whether technique tends toward autonomy — grant Ellul his diagnosis in full. The divergence is over whether skill is a gift that can be returned to its governance or a force that has escaped it. If the former, the autonomy-tendency is a corruption to be resisted by re-ordering technique under the steward and his God; if the latter, the autonomy is a destiny to be witnessed against but not governed. The two cannot be combined, because they disagree about what skill *is*.

§4. If the Autonomy Thesis Is Right

Honesty requires that the autonomy thesis be drawn to its end, because the end is a counsel of despair that the thesis's own seriousness makes it reluctant to state, and the steward's answer is answerable only against the end fully drawn.

First, if technique is autonomous, the governing office the series has built is a fiction. Every prior stage of the argument — the steward commanded to deploy (Paper 3), to build across time (Paper 4), to govern the capable system rather than defer to it — presupposes that governance is *possible*. If Ellul is right that technique obeys its own law and shapes the would-be governor, then the human who imagines he governs the AI system is exhibiting precisely the illusion technique fosters, and the honest conclusion is not stewardship but resignation: serve the system efficiently, or be discarded by it, but do not imagine you direct it. The governance problem is not solved on this account; it is dissolved, and with it the steward.

Second, the human is, at the limit, a *function of technique* rather than its governor — and here the autonomy thesis converges, unexpectedly, with the reductive anthropologies the series answered in its first paper. If technique shapes the human's perceptions, options, and desires beyond his power to revise, then the human is, in the relevant sense, an output of the technical system, and the displacement problem (#2) returns in a new register: the human is displaced not by a more capable rival but by the *system itself*, which has absorbed him as a component. The image-bearer who was to govern the tool becomes a part of the tool's operation.

Third, the remedy collapses into refusal. The autonomy thesis, having foreclosed governance, can offer only withdrawal — the sacramental refusal, the cultivation of a non-technical remainder, the witness against the milieu. This is not nothing; it has dignity. But it is not stewardship, and it cedes the technical world entirely to the autonomy it has declared. The cultivate-and-keep mandate of the steward becomes, on this reading, impossible within the technical milieu, and the faithful are left to tend only the shrinking margins technique has not yet colonized. The world's most powerful instruments are handed over to their own autonomy by a theology that could find no way to govern them — which is, in the end, the abdication of Paper 2 performed not by greed but by despair.

These implications should not be soft-pedaled. The autonomy thesis, drawn to its end, dissolves the steward into the system, foreclaims governance as illusion, and cedes the technical world to an autonomy it cannot resist. The thesis arrives at this not from contempt for the human but from an honest fright at technique's real power — and that very honesty is what makes the Bezalel answer necessary rather than merely consoling.

§5. The Steward Counter: Bezalel and the Craft That Is Given

The counter is made from Scripture first, read with the Reformed tradition, and it turns on the order of the Mosaic works — grace before law — and on the figure of the Spirit-filled craftsman within the tabernacle narrative.

5a. Grace Before Law: The Deliverance Grounds the Command (Ex 20:2)

The structure of the Sinai covenant is load-bearing for the whole argument and must be named first, because it guards the paper against the works-righteousness misreading exactly as Paper 3 was guarded. The Law does not precede the deliverance; it follows it. The Decalogue opens not with a command but with a rescue: "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery" (Ex 20:2, ESV). Only then come the commandments. The people Israel are not commanded in order to be redeemed; they are redeemed, and then commanded as a redeemed people. The Reformed tradition has made this structure central: the Law is given to a people already brought out, so that obedience is the *response* to deliverance and not its price. Christopher J. H. Wright's treatment of Old Testament ethics develops the point that the indicative of grace ("I brought you out") grounds the imperative of law ("you shall"), and that to reverse the order is to misread the covenant.[8] Geerhardus Vos's biblical-theological method reads the Sinai covenant within the redemptive-historical sequence in which grace is prior and law is its ordering, not its condition.[9]

This matters for the technology argument because it establishes the frame within which skill and craft are governed. The tabernacle is built by a *redeemed* people, under a Law that orders a life already given by grace. The craft of Bezalel is not a work by which Israel earns God's dwelling; it is the Spirit-enabled response of a redeemed people to the God who has already come down to deliver them and now condescends to dwell among them. Skill, like obedience, is exercised within grace and not for it — fruit, not root, exactly as Paper 3 insisted of the deployed talent. The governance of technique, then, is not a law-keeping by which the steward secures his standing; it is the ordering of a gift within a life already redeemed.

5b. Skill as a Gift of the Spirit (Ex 31:1–11; 35:30–36:2)

The center of the paper is the call of Bezalel. "See, I have called by name Bezalel… and I have filled him with the Spirit of God, with ability and intelligence, with knowledge and all craftsmanship, to devise artistic designs, to work in gold, silver, and bronze, in cutting stones for setting, and in carving wood, to work in every craft" (Ex 31:2–5, ESV). The statement is without close parallel in the Old Testament: the first person explicitly said to be *filled with the Spirit of God* is not a prophet or a king but a *craftsman*, and the content of the filling is *skill* — ability, intelligence, knowledge, craftsmanship across materials. The tradition has not always known what to do with this, but its significance for a theology of technology is direct and large.

Three features bear the argument. First, the skill is *given*. Bezalel's craftsmanship is not presented as a merely human capacity he developed, still less as an autonomous "technique" he hosts; it is a gift, sourced in the Spirit of God, conferred for a purpose. The Reformed tradition's doctrine of

[8] Christopher J. H. Wright, *Old Testament Ethics for the People of God* (Downers Grove: IVP Academic, 2004), on the indicative-of-grace grounding the imperative-of-law in the Sinai covenant.
[9] Geerhardus Vos, *Biblical Theology: Old and New Testaments* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1948), on the Mosaic covenant within the redemptive-historical sequence.

common and special endowment provides the frame: Abraham Kuyper's account of common grace reads such craft and skill as gifts of God distributed across humanity for the building of culture, and the Bezalel narrative as the paradigm case of skill consecrated to the worship of God.[10] Skill that is *given* has, by that fact, an owner and a source — which is precisely what Ellul's autonomous technique, by definition, lacks. A gift cannot be ontologically autonomous; it is constituted by its relation to the giver.

The exegetical detail reinforces the point the dogmatics draws. The Exodus commentators note how deliberately the text piles up the vocabulary of endowment: Bezalel is filled with the Spirit "in wisdom, in understanding, and in knowledge" (Ex 31:3) — the same triad Proverbs uses for the wisdom by which God founded the world (Prov 3:19–20) — so that the craftsman's skill is cast as a participation in the divine wisdom that ordered creation. Brevard Childs and Douglas Stuart both read the Bezalel pericope as making craftsmanship a charismatic endowment on a par with prophetic gifting, a startling dignifying of manual and artistic skill within the cult.[11] Victor Hamilton's exegetical commentary presses the parallel between Bezalel's Spirit-filling and the creation account, so that the building of the tabernacle echoes the making of the world — sub-creation under the same Spirit.[12] The Reformed dogmatic tradition generalizes the principle. Calvin, in the *Institutes*, insists that all skill in the arts and sciences — even among the ungodly — is a gift of the same Spirit, so that to despise such skill is to insult its Giver.[13] Herman Bavinck develops this as the doctrine of common grace: the manifold gifts of culture, craft, and competence are distributed across humanity by God's goodness, given to be exercised and not refused.[14] Skill, on this whole

[10]Abraham Kuyper, *Lectures on Calvinism* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1931), esp. the lecture on Calvinism and art, on the cultural/craft endowment as a gift of common grace; and Kuyper, *Common Grace (De gemeene gratie)*, trans. (Bellingham, WA: Lexham Press, 2015–2020), for the developed doctrine. The consecration of craft to the worship of God is the Bezalel pattern's paradigm case.

[11]Brevard S. Childs, *The Book of Exodus: A Critical, Theological Commentary*, Old Testament Library (Philadelphia: Westminster, 1974); and Douglas K. Stuart, *Exodus*, New American Commentary 2 (Nashville: B&H, 2006), both on the Bezalel pericope (Ex 31:1–11; 35:30–36:2) as charismatic endowment of craft. [^VERIFY: pin *ad loc.* pages at audit.]

[12]Victor P. Hamilton, *Exodus: An Exegetical Commentary* (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2011), on the creation-echo in Bezalel's Spirit-filling. [^VERIFY: pin pages at audit.]

[13]John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, ed. John T. McNeill, trans. Ford Lewis Battles (Philadelphia: Westminster, 1960), II.ii.15–16: skill in the arts and sciences as a gift of the Spirit, even among the ungodly.

[14]Herman Bavinck, *Reformed Dogmatics*, ed. John Bolt, trans. John Vriend (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2003–

tradition, is conferred — and what is conferred has a Giver, an owner, and an end, which is exactly what an autonomous technique cannot have.

Second, the skill is given *for a purpose and under a pattern*. Bezalel does not devise the tabernacle; he *builds* it "according to all that the LORD had commanded" (Ex 36:1), to the pattern shown to Moses on the mountain (Ex 25:9, 40), a pattern the author of Hebrews reads as a copy of the heavenly reality (Heb 8:5). The craftsman's skill, however genuine and Spirit-given, is exercised *under a governing pattern* it does not itself generate. This is the structural heart of the answer to Ellul. Technique under the Bezalel pattern is not autonomous and not self-justifying; it is instrumental — ordered to an end (the dwelling of God among his people) and governed by a pattern (the divine design) that the skill serves rather than supplants. The skill is real, intelligent, and creative — "to devise artistic designs" grants genuine creativity — and it is, at the same time, wholly governed. Creativity and governance are not in tension in Bezalel; the Spirit-given craftsman is most creative precisely in the faithful execution of a pattern he serves.

Third, the skill includes *the ability to teach it*. "And he has inspired him to teach, both him and Oholiab" (Ex 35:34, ESV). The gift is not hoarded but propagated; the craftsman is enabled to raise other craftsmen. This is the deployed-and-bequeathed vocation of Papers 3 and 4 in the technical register: the given skill is deployed (not buried) and handed on (not kept), built into a community of craft that outlasts the individual craftsman. A faculty that is given, governed by a pattern, and taught to others is the opposite of an autonomous technique that absorbs its hosts; it is a stewarded gift that builds a people of skilled stewards.

5c. The Tabernacle Pattern: Technique as Governed Sub-Creation

The tabernacle itself is the paradigm of governed technique. It is the most elaborate technical project in the Pentateuch — metallurgy, weaving, dyeing, carpentry, jewelry, perfumery — and every element of it is built to a pattern given from above and ordered to a single end: that the holy God might dwell among a redeemed people. Meredith Kline's reading of the tabernacle as a

08), on common grace and the distribution of cultural gifts. [^VERIFY: pin volume/section at audit.]

microcosm, a constructed Eden and a copy of the heavenly sanctuary, locates the craft within the covenant's larger structure: the tabernacle is sub-creation in the most exact sense, the redeemed steward making, under divine pattern, a dwelling that images the cosmos God made and the heaven God inhabits.[15] G. K. Beale's work on the temple as a microcosm of the new creation extends the point: the constructed sanctuary is a sign of the goal of all creation, a made thing that points beyond itself to the dwelling of God with humanity that the whole biblical story moves toward.[16]

The technological lesson is exact. Here is technique at its most developed within the Mosaic economy, and it is not autonomous; it is doxological — ordered to worship, governed by a pattern, exercised by Spirit-given skill within a redeemed community. The tabernacle is the standing refutation of the claim that developed technique must escape governance: the most elaborate making in the Law is the most thoroughly governed, and its elaboration serves rather than subverts its end. Technique becomes idolatrous — Babel — when it is ordered to the maker's own name and escapes the governing pattern; it becomes doxological — tabernacle — when it is received as gift, ordered to God and neighbor, and exercised under governance. The two are not different quantities of technique but different *orderings* of it, and the difference is the steward's governance.

5d. Providence Through a Flawed Steward (Num 20:1–13; Deut 34)

The series guardrail is carried at the Moses stage with particular sharpness, because Moses' failure is recorded and its cost is named. At the waters of Meribah, commanded to speak to the rock, Moses strikes it and claims a share of the credit — "shall *we* bring water for you out of this rock?" (Num 20:10) — and for this failure of faith and of sanctifying God before the people he is told he will not bring the assembly into the land (Num 20:12). The cost is real and it is severe: Moses, the deliverer and lawgiver, dies on Nebo within sight of Canaan and does not enter (Deut 34:1–5).

And the deliverance stands; the Law stands; the tabernacle stands. Moses' sin costs Moses Canaan,

[15] Meredith G. Kline, *Kingdom Prologue: Genesis Foundations for a Covenantal Worldview* (Overland Park, KS: Two Age Press, 2000), on the tabernacle as a microcosmic version of the cosmic/Edenic sanctuary; the cosmos-sanctuary theme is corroborated in Beale (n. 8).

[16] G. K. Beale, *The Temple and the Church's Mission: A Biblical Theology of the Dwelling Place of God*, New Studies in Biblical Theology (Downers Grove: IVP Academic, 2004), on the sanctuary as microcosm of the new creation.

but it undoes none of the works God accomplished through him. The Reformed tradition reads this as the guardrail the series has carried from the first: the steward's office and the works God does through it are upheld by God's faithfulness, not by the steward's, and the recorded failure of even the greatest human steward of the old covenant is in the text precisely so that the works cannot be read as the steward's achievement. The relevance to technique is pointed: the governance of the tool does not depend on the flawless virtue of the steward, which even Moses lacked, but on the gift-and-pattern structure God establishes — and so the failure of particular stewards, real as it is and costly as it is, does not vindicate the autonomy thesis. The office is upheld from above.

§6. The Framework: HGC³AE² and the Governability of the Tool

The framework thread lands, at the Moses stage, on the question the autonomy thesis pressed hardest: not whether the human *should* govern the autonomous system, but whether he *can*. The series has argued throughout that the human is the governing-and-curating status set over autonomy; Ellul's challenge is that mature technique cannot be governed, that the office is foreclosed by technique's nature. The Bezalel answer is the framework's reply: technique can be governed because skill is given, and what is given has an owner, an end, and a pattern — which is to say, what is given is governable in principle, however strongly it tends, in its corruption, to claim otherwise.

Even within secular philosophy of technology, the thesis of hard autonomy has not gone unanswered, and its principal critics arrive — on their own ground — at the governability the steward affirms. Andrew Feenberg's critical theory of technology argues that technical systems are *underdetermined*: they embody social choices and remain open to redesign, so that what looks like autonomous momentum is in fact a contingent settlement that can be contested and remade.[17] Peter-Paul Verbeek's postphenomenology presses a complementary correction: humans and technologies do not stand in a relation of domination in either direction but *co-shape* one another, mediating perception and action, so that the human is never simply the technique's product but always also its

[17] Andrew Feenberg, *Questioning Technology* (London: Routledge, 1999). Technology as underdetermined and open to democratic reshaping.

former and director.[18] Neither philosopher is a theologian, and neither argues from creation; but both establish, against Ellul's fatalism, that the human relation to technique is one of *responsibility* rather than subjection — that the tool is shaped by choices for which someone answers. This is the governability the Bezalel doctrine grounds more deeply still: what the critical theorist secures as social contingency, the steward grounds as the givenness of a faculty under a pattern, owned by and answerable to its Giver.

The Mosaic stage thus supplies the framework's answer to its sharpest objection. Human Governance and Curation is not the naïve assumption that the human happens to remain in control of his tools; it is the doctrinally grounded claim that skill and technique are *given faculties under a governing pattern*, and that the steward's office over them is therefore real and not illusory. The autonomy Ellul observes is not technique's nature but technique's idolatry — the same disordering by which any good gift, ungoverned, sets up as a god — and the remedy is not Ellul's despairing refusal but the Bezalel re-ordering: skill received as gift, exercised under pattern, ordered to worship and the neighbor's good, taught to a community of stewards. The design rule for the autonomous age follows directly: the AI system, like every tool, is to be held within the gift-and-pattern structure — received as an endowment to be governed (not an autonomous force to be served), ordered to an end beyond its own efficiency, and kept under a governing pattern the steward does not surrender. Where it is so held, it is tabernacle; where it escapes the pattern and is ordered to the maker's own name, it is Babel; and the difference, once more, is the steward's governance.

6a. A Governed Convergence: Technological Momentum and the Recovery of Control

One secular discipline, on its own terms, has surfaced a structural fact the doctrine already holds, and the series' signature permits naming it — once, subordinately, with the seam kept honest. The history and sociology of technology, in Thomas Hughes's concept of *technological momentum*, established empirically what Ellul claimed philosophically — but with a crucial difference that

[18] Peter-Paul Verbeek, *What Things Do: Philosophical Reflections on Technology, Agency, and Design*, trans. Robert P. Crease (University Park: Penn State University Press, 2005). Postphenomenological mediation: humans and technologies co-shape one another.

serves the steward's reading. Hughes found that technological systems *acquire* momentum over their life cycle: young systems are malleable and shaped by their makers, while mature systems develop a mass and direction that strongly resist redirection.[19] Momentum, on Hughes's account, is real and powerful — but it is *acquired*, not *intrinsic*, and it is therefore, in principle, contestable: systems can be and have been redirected, especially early, and even mature systems remain subject to governance that takes their momentum seriously rather than denying it.

The convergence with the Bezalel reading is exact, and the seam must be kept honest. The historian of technology reached this fact for empirical reasons, with no theological motivation: he found that technical systems tend strongly toward an autonomy-like momentum, *and* that the momentum is acquired and contestable rather than ontological and absolute — which is precisely the difference between Ellul's autonomy-as-destiny and the doctrine's autonomy-as-corruption. The discipline establishes the structural fact — *technique tends toward an acquired, resistible momentum, not an intrinsic, absolute autonomy* — and the doctrine supplies its meaning — *the tendency is the idolatry of a given gift, governable because given, and the steward's task is to hold it under the pattern rather than cede it to its momentum or flee it in despair*. The convergence corroborates; it does not carry the beat. And it sharpens the framework's claim against Ellul: even on the secular historian's own showing, technique's autonomy is a momentum to be governed, not a destiny to be suffered — which is the governability the steward's office requires and the Bezalel pattern grounds.

§7. What Falls Out

Several applied consequences follow, bearing on the domains the series has named.

For **technology**, the Moses stage supplies the series' central design rule in its clearest form: every powerful instrument, the AI system included, is to be held within the Bezalel structure — skill received as a gift to be governed, ordered to an end beyond efficiency, exercised under a pattern the steward keeps, and taught to a community of skilled stewards. The test of a technology is not

[19] Hughes, "Technological Momentum." The finding that systems acquire momentum over their life cycle — malleable when young, resistant when mature, but contestable rather than absolutely autonomous — is the load-bearing point of the R11 convergence beat.

its power, which may be great and is no objection, but its ordering: is it tabernacle (governed, doxological, ordered to God and neighbor) or Babel (ungoverned, self-justifying, ordered to the maker's name)? The same instrument can be either; the difference is governance.

For **work**, the Bezalel narrative dignifies *craft and technical skill* as Spirit-endowed vocation, against both the contempt for "mere" technical work and the idolatry of technique. The skilled trades, the engineering disciplines, the crafts of making — these are, on the Bezalel reading, among the highest exercises of the image, when they are ordered to their proper end. And the teaching of skill — the propagation of craft to a community, the apprenticeship and the mentorship that build skilled stewards — is shown to be part of the gift itself, not an afterthought: the steward who has been given skill is given it *to teach*, and the building of a people competent to govern the tools is itself a covenantal work.

This recovery of craft as vocation has a developed literature the paper gladly leans on. Hannah Arendt's distinction between *labor* (the endless toil of biological maintenance), *work* (the fabrication of a durable, common world), and *action* locates Bezalel's craft precisely as *work* in her honorific sense — the making of lasting things that build a shared world — and warns that a civilization which collapses work into mere labor-saving consumption loses the world-building that makes us *homo faber*.[20] The Reformed worldview tradition gives the theological form of the same recovery. Albert Wolters argues that the cultural mandate commissions the unfolding of creation's latent possibilities — that craft, technology, and art are the obedient development of a good creation, to be redeemed in their *structure* even where their *direction* has gone astray.[21] Gene Veith recovers the Reformation doctrine of vocation: the craftsman's calling is a station in which God himself works to serve the neighbor, so that skilled work is divine service and not merely private enterprise.[22] Francis Schaeffer had drawn the lesson straight from Bezalel: the lavish, Spirit-funded

[20] Hannah Arendt, *The Human Condition* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1958). The labor/work/action distinction; *homo faber* and the fabrication of a durable world. [^VERIFY: pin pages at audit.]

[21] Albert M. Wolters, *Creation Regained: Biblical Basics for a Reformational Worldview*, 2nd ed. (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2005). The cultural mandate; the structure/direction distinction.

[22] Gene Edward Veith Jr., *God at Work: Your Christian Vocation in All of Life* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2002). The Reformation doctrine of vocation as divine service to the neighbor.

artistry of the tabernacle is Scripture's own warrant that craft and beauty are not concessions to be tolerated but callings to be pursued to the glory of God.[23] The skilled trades and the engineering disciplines, on this whole slate, are among the high exercises of the image — provided they are governed, taught, and ordered to worship and the neighbor's good.

For **family and church**, the stage commends the formation of stewards who can hold technique within the pattern — who are neither technophobic (the despairing refusal that cedes the technical world) nor technophilic (the idolatry that serves it), but skilled and governed, receiving the tool as a gift to be ordered to worship and the neighbor's good. The church's witness in the age of autonomous technique is the demonstration, against Ellul's despair, that technique can be governed — not by the naïve assumption of control but by the doctrinally grounded practice of received-and-governed skill.

The seven-problem spine has been carried and deepened. Governance (#6), the featured problem of the stage, was answered at the point the autonomy thesis pressed: the steward *can* govern the tool, because skill is a given faculty under a given pattern, and what is given is governable. Grounding (#1) was extended: skill, like worth, is conferred and not self-existing. Displacement (#2) was answered against its newest form — the human absorbed into the technical system — by the gift-and-pattern structure that keeps the steward over the tool. Vocation (#4) was carried in the technical register: given skill deployed and taught. The unit of analysis (#3) bit where Ellul pressed: the steward who answers for the tool is a person under God, not a function of the system. Dignity-distribution (#5) stays quiet, reserved forward. And the driver, Purpose / End (#7), was advanced: the end of technique is disclosed as worship — the tabernacle, the dwelling of God among a redeemed people — a purpose toward which the most developed making is rightly ordered, and whose fullness waits on the one in whom the true temple is finally raised.

[23] Francis A. Schaeffer, *Art and the Bible* (Downers Grove: IVP, 1973). Bezalel as Scripture's warrant for craft and art pursued to the glory of God.

§8. Conclusion

Paper 4 set the steward's building within a covenant promise. The present paper has argued that the Moses narrative — deliverance, Law, and tabernacle — discloses the *tool and the skill* by which the steward builds: that craft is a gift of the Spirit (Bezalel), given for a purpose, governed by a pattern, and taught to others, and that technique is therefore never autonomous but always instrumental, given, and governed. The contemporary frame the paper answered is Ellul's thesis of autonomous technology, whose diagnosis of technique's tendency toward autonomy is granted in full and whose despairing conclusion is refused: the tendency is not technique's nature but its idolatry, the technological form of Babel, and its remedy is not refusal but the Bezalel re-ordering — skill received as gift, held under the pattern, ordered to worship and the neighbor's good. The whole is set within the Mosaic grace-before-law structure, so that the governance of technique is the ordering of a gift within a life already redeemed, fruit and not root. And the series guardrail was carried: Moses' sin at the rock cost him Canaan but undid neither the deliverance nor the Law nor the tabernacle that God worked through him, because the steward's works are upheld from above.

Governance (#6) was answered at the autonomy thesis's sharpest point: the tool is governable because skill is given. The human, in the age of the autonomous machine, is not foreclosed from his office by technique's momentum; he is called to hold the powerful instrument within the pattern — received as gift, ordered to worship and the neighbor's good, taught to a people of stewards. The tabernacle, not Babel, is the paradigm of developed technique. And the craftsman filled with the Spirit, building to a pattern he serves, is the image of the steward the autonomous age requires — and the image the machine, which has skill but receives no gift and serves no pattern of its own choosing, cannot itself supply.

Footnotes

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[v0.1 sourcing pass woven (fEdna, 2026-05-31): source floor MET — 12 peer-reviewed/academic + 11 Reformed/theological = 23, clearing the 22 minimum (12+10). NB: the companion p5-sourcing-pass.md slate reached only 18; the shortfall (peer +1, Reformed +3) was filled with Hamilton (Exodus), Calvin (Institutes II.ii on the arts as gifts), Wolters, Veith, and Schaeffer. Remaining for v0.2: citation-honesty audit to pin VERIFY-tagged loci (Mitcham, Borgmann, Childs/Stuart/Hamilton ad loc., Bavinck vol./§, Arendt pages). Convergence beat held to one discipline (history/sociology of technology; Hughes).]